

it is better to work with independent SMEs and consultants based on your requirement.”

There is no question that technology has radically changed the way companies do business, extend their influence in the global marketplace, and improve the quality and efficiency of their day-to-day operations. The price of progress, however, is not without its downside, particularly the cost associated with it and a high value that is sometimes placed on impersonal communication rather than human interaction.

Raj brings to light other areas of concern. He says, “Widespread access to information comes with challenges, specifically how a company can preserve and protect intellectual property. As employees and guests enter the workplace, their mobile devices automatically register and authenticate. Access to information and services is tightly controlled based on user profile, time, location or other contextual attributes.

“One of the biggest threats are cyber attacks. Whether large or small, these are real and have the ability to inflict real damage to businesses. The risks and costs are real, too. Cyber security is one of the fastest-growing industries and, unfortunately, is a necessary part of technology.

“Leveraging advanced technology to support humanity in the workplace is a transformational concept. Organisations that get it right will attract, engage and retain the very best of talent.”

Measuring success

Mathews adds, “ROI may not be easily quantifiable. However, studies have shown that it certainly enhances productivity, reduces fire-fighting operations, optimises resources and so on.

“The ability to continuously monitor how a workplace is used means we can see changes and analyse their impact in shorter time frames. The workplace can then be altered to utilise the space and make it more efficient. But, adaptable workplaces and furniture are needed.

“Technology is the most important factor and it is forever changing. It also contributes to the need for flexible and

future-proof designs.”

“We are seeing (or probably not seeing) more things that are wired (or wirelessly connected) to devices or networks. Smartphones and wearables (like Fitbits and Apple Watches) are being integrated into the workplace. Devices are keeping track of where we are and how we are using space. Siri and Alexa, our virtual assistants, are becoming more like real assistants. These are listening, answering questions, creating our to-do lists, making phone calls, scheduling meetings and even ordering coffee (making coffee is not far off!). AI is starting to understand who we are, what we do and what we want or need, in addition to controlling the lights and temperature of our workplaces,” concludes Raj.

—Nidhi Arora, executive editor, EFY

Business Opportunities In Hotel Automation Technology

► **Technology in the hotel business is evolving at a rapid pace, and is proving to be an essential aspect for hoteliers looking to improve the smooth running of their businesses**

India’s hospitality industry is readily adopting technology to provide better services. As customers are increasingly relying on digital platforms, hotels too are turning to technology to keep up. This has introduced a new wave of business opportunities for tech-solution providers in India.

Technologies like appliance automation, services control, tracking

solutions, cloud-based data collection and analytics are garnering great demand for their significant impact on the hotel business.

Aditya Sanghi, chief executive officer and co-founder, Hotelogix Inc., explains, “Until recently, 3-star and above hotels were running on older server-based technology, not connected to the digital world. This created a technological bottleneck for them. Now, these are effectively embracing cloud-based solutions to connect with customers in real time. Traditional hotel chains are expanding their property count by up to three times and are, hence, in need of centralised monitoring and control systems. Moreover, delivering consistently good service requires automation. This is driving the demand for such technologies. Even smaller hotels (with no more than 20 rooms) are willingly adopting such solutions.”

Market reports suggest that by 2021, the global smart hospitality market will grow to US\$ 18.1 billion at a CAGR of 25.8 per cent. This will be driven by hotel automation platforms, which can generate a global market of US\$ 4.3 billion by 2021, at 6.5 per cent CAGR.

Why hotels will invest in these technologies

Srijith Sivan, business development manager, BuildTrack, says, “The centralised system offers greater degree of control, safety and operational cost management. Energy and resource usage optimisation can lead to cost savings in the range of 10 to 25 per cent.”

Sanghi adds, “These solutions can help double the occupancy rate and help hotels make more money. Cloud-based technologies can strengthen their marketing capacities and guest management strategies. Through data-driven insights, owners can take important business decisions, like guest experience improvement areas, target market for better business, revenue management strategies and so on.”

Sivan gives an idea on the investment required. He says, “Starting costs for room automation can vary between ₹ 50,000 and ₹ 150,000. For